33. Yoga — postures, breathing and relaxation (a safe 30–45 minute sequence)

Oracle OS guide. Based on the Government of India (Ministry of AYUSH) "Common Yoga Protocol" (in the library, **with photographs of every posture**), the Yoga Sutras of Patanjali and the Hatha Yoga Pradipika (classic texts, also in the library).

What it is

Yoga (Sanskrit *yuj*, "to join") is an Indian discipline over 2,000 years old. The **Yoga Sutras of Patanjali** (c. 2nd century BCE–5th century CE) describe 8 limbs: ethics (yama), discipline (niyama), posture (asana), breath (pranayama), withdrawal of the senses (pratyahara), concentration (dharana), meditation (dhyana) and absorption (samadhi). **Hatha Yoga** (Hatha Yoga Pradipika, 15th century) added postures, breath and energy techniques. Modern posture-based yoga developed mainly in the 20th century.

Safety

- Empty stomach (2–3 h after a meal). Mat or blanket, loose clothes.
- Never force: tension yes, pain no. Breathe through the nose; don't hold the breath in postures.
- **Pregnancy**: avoid strong twists, lying face down, Kapalabhati and inversions; prefer prenatal yoga.
- **High blood pressure, glaucoma, heart disease**: avoid inversions (head below heart) and Kapalabhati.
- **Disc herniation or sciatica**: avoid deep straight-legged forward bends; prefer gentle back-bends (Cobra) if they ease it.
- After surgery, with osteoporosis or injuries: adapt and seek guidance.

1. Prayer / intention (1 min)

Seated or standing, eyes closed, attention on the breath. Chant "Om" or set an intention.

2. Loosening (5 min)

- **Neck**: bend forward/back, sideways, and rotate gently, 4× each.
- **Shoulders**: hands on shoulders, elbow circles 5× forward and 5× back.
- **Trunk**: feet apart, twist side to side letting the arms swing, 5×.
- **Knees**: hands on knees, bend and straighten, 5×.

3. Standing postures

- **Tadasana (mountain)**: feet together, raise the arms breathing in, rise onto the toes, 10 s, lower breathing out.
- **Vrksasana (tree)**: sole of one foot on the inner thigh of the other leg (never on the knee), hands together at chest or overhead, gaze on one point, 20–30 s each side. Balance and focus.

- **Pada-hastasana (hands to feet)**: breathe in arms up, breathe out folding forward from the hips; knees may bend. Avoid with acute low back pain.
- **Ardha Chakrasana (half wheel)**: hands on the waist, breathe in and lean back, neck relaxed, 10 s.
- **Trikonasana (triangle)**: feet wide, arms out, bend sideways sliding a hand down the leg, other arm up, 20 s each side.

4. Seated postures

- **Bhadrasana (butterfly)**: soles together, knees down, back straight.
- **Vajrasana (diamond)**: sitting on the heels, back straight. Good after meals, for breathing and meditation.
- **Ardha Ustrasana (half camel)**: kneeling, hands on the waist, push the hips forward and lean back carefully, 10 s.
- **Sasankasana (hare/child)**: from Vajrasana, fold forward arms outstretched, forehead to the floor, 30 s. Relaxes the back.
- **Vakrasana (twist)**: seated, one leg crossed over the other, turn the trunk toward the bent knee, 20 s each side.

5. Face-down postures

- **Makarasana (crocodile)**: lie face down, forehead on crossed hands, relax. Eases the low back.
- **Bhujangasana (cobra)**: hands beside the chest, breathe in lifting the chest, elbows bent, hips down, 10–20 s. Helpful for low back pain that eases with extension.
- **Salabhasana (locust)**: arms by the sides, lift the straight legs (one at a time if hard), 10 s. Strengthens the back.

6. Lying on the back

- **Setu Bandhasana (bridge)**: knees bent, lift the hips, 10–20 s.
- **Uttanapadasana**: lift the straight legs to 30°, 10 s (bend the knees if the low back hurts).
- **Pavanamuktasana (wind-relieving)**: hug the knees to the chest, rock gently.
- **Shavasana (corpse)**: lying, arms apart, palms up, eyes closed; relax part by part from feet to head, 5–10 min. Essential: don't skip it.

7. Sun Salutation (Surya Namaskar) — 12 movements linked to the breath

1 Hands at the chest. 2. In: arms up, slight back-bend. 3. Out: fold forward, hands to the floor. 4. In: right leg back, knee down, look ahead. 5. Out: other leg back, plank. 6. Out: knees, chest and chin to the floor. 7. In: cobra. 8. Out: hips up (downward dog). 9. In: right foot forward between the hands. 10. Out: left foot forward, fold. 11. In: rise with arms up. 12. Out: hands to the chest. Repeat leading with the left leg. Start with 2–4 slow rounds.

8. Pranayama (breathing)

- **Belly breathing**: hand on the belly, breathe in through the nose and the belly rises, breathe out and it falls. The basis of everything.
- **Nadi Shodhana / Anulom Vilom (alternate nostril)**: right thumb closes the right nostril, breathe in left; ring finger closes the left, breathe out right; breathe in right; switch; breathe out left. 5–10 minutes. Calming and balancing.
- **Bhramari (bee)**: breathe in, and on the out-breath hum "mmm" like a bee with the ears closed. 5–10×. Excellent for anxiety and insomnia.
- **Sitali (cooling)**: curl the tongue into a tube, breathe in through it, out through the nose. For heat.
- **Ujjayi (ocean)**: gently narrow the throat so the breath sounds like the sea; slow rhythm.
- **Kapalabhati (skull-shining)**: short forceful out-breaths through the nose by pulling in the belly, passive in-breath; 30 × 3 rounds. **Avoid** in pregnancy, high blood pressure, heart disease, hernia, epilepsy and menstruation.
- Long breath retentions (kumbhaka) and bandhas: only with a teacher.

9. Meditation and closing

Sit upright 5–10 min watching the breath (see the "Meditation" guide). End with an intention (sankalpa) and a few seconds of gratitude.

Short sequences for real situations

- **Stiff low back**: cat–cow, child, crocodile, cobra, bridge, lying rotation, shavasana.
- **Before sleep**: legs up the wall (lying with the legs resting on a wall, 5 min), reclined butterfly, Bhramari, shavasana.
- **Anxiety/fear**: belly breathing with a longer out-breath than in-breath (4 in, 6–8 out), Bhramari, alternate nostril.
- **After carrying loads**: child, cat–cow, seated twist, cross-body shoulder, forearm stretches.